

RETRO CAMERA APPS

THE EASIEST WAY TO BECOME A TIME TRAVELLER

ADITYA MADANAPALLE | aditya@digit.in

One of the simplest ways to liven up your social media streams is to use a dose of nostalgia for the images that you share. The application stores are full of various retro camera options, but these apps below let you take the experience to the next level, by giving users granular control, and authentically simulating the experience of using legacy and vintage equipment. If you know exactly what you are aiming for, the same end results obtained from all these apps can be achieved using Snapseed or Photoshopper Express.

GET THE DARK ROOM EXPERIENCE

Darkr is a rather complicated application that gives you the experience of working in a real darkroom and developing black and white photos, and working with developer chemicals. This app is particularly good with portraits and landscapes.

1. Fire up the application and select pocket camera to click a photograph. Alternatively, you can fire up the darkroom, and tap on the floral icon on the top right corner to select an image from your phone. The images show up as negatives.
2. Tap on the darkroom icon again. Now you work with what is known as a test strip. This involves developing

a part of the image till you have just the amount of exposure and contrast required. Exposure means the duration for which the image is allowed to develop. The longer the exposure, the darker the image. Ideally, this should be done till the whitest part of the



image is as white as possible, and the darkest part of the image is as dark as possible. This is a kind of colour correction. Swipe downwards to increase the duration of the exposure. Keep doing this till there is no loss of detail in the darkest parts of the image. Swiping left or right allows you to increase or decrease the contrast, by simulating special filters that are used in the darkroom.

3. Next, you can crop, dodge, burn or blur portions of the image. If portions of the image are too light or too dark, the burn and dodge options can be used to correct that. When choosing either burn

or dodge, you can apply a mask to portions of the image, to make sure only those portions get burned. One option is to slap on a mask to the entire image, and paint away portions where the burn effect should not be applied. For a smooth burn or dodge, there is also the option of adding a gradient mask, that slowly fades a burn. These options allow you to fine tune the contrast and exposure in parts of the image. In traditional dark rooms, these effects were done using a brush, or strips of paper to control the exposure.

That is it, you are done. You can save the image to the film strip. While the base app is free, however, there are in-app purchases for toners, micromanaging the layers, and film emulsions. The cheapest option is to go all in and unlock everything for ₹300.

MICROMANAGE RETRO EFFECTS

Most “retro” camera apps provide the experience with a random set of filters that are slapped on to the photo. At times, you may be required to directly shoot from the app itself, which provides an image that leaves little scope for further manipulation. Retro Cam allows you to micromanage a number of aspects that make a photo retro, in a step-by-step manner. Bear in mind that the app works